This did not prevent the myth from taking a tenacious hold on the imagination and enduring through the centuries to the present day.*

From the few glimpses that Abu'l Fazl allows, it appears not impossible that it was Daniyal who was involved in some indiscretion in the admittedly large imperial harem, for which Akbar then tried to remove him from the court. One might even surmise that if Daniyal did, in fact, arrange for a clandestine meeting in the harem it may even possibly have been with an influential sister or matriarch to gauge the support he had in an increasingly unforgiving battle for supremacy between Salim and his siblings. By having him married to the daughter of the extremely powerful Qulij Khan, Akbar may even have been bolstering his younger son's ambitions vis-a-vis Salim. By the time William Finch arrived at Lahore, Daniyal was long dead and it was Jahangir, as Prince Salim, that the popular imagination would remember as having tussled with Padshah Akbar. And, as with all bazaar gossip and European fantasies, the tussle was presumed to have been over sexual liaisons and the story was conflated to make of Salim the hero of the Anarkali saga.

Daniyal, however, was proving very resistant to the idea of marching to the Deccan. Along with Abdur Rahim, the khankhanan, who had been assigned to the mission, the men dithered at Sirhind, citing inclement weather conditions, till Akbar, irritated and impatient, recalled the prince to court. It was decided, moreover, that with Murad already in the region, it would perhaps prove impossible to have both the brothers leading the expedition, exacerbating rivalries.

At the court in Lahore the mood was sombre as Faizi was dying, at the age of only forty-eight. One night Akbar went to visit the poet and held the dying man's head in his lap and tried to revive him. 'O Shaikh Ji,' said Akbar, broken-hearted, 'I have brought Hakim Ali with me, why do you say nothing?' Receiving no answer, Akbar in his despair flung his turban on the ground but Faizi was beyond the help of the courtly physicians, and even the prayers of the Padshah, and passed away from complications brought on by the asthma he had suffered from throughout his life. Badauni's cantankerous assessment of his death was that 'since he had, in despite of Musalmans, associated and been mixed up with dogs day and night, they say that at the moment of death they heard him bark like a dog'. These words, noted down in Badauni's covertly written account, are all the more graceless because Faizi had been unfailingly kind to the temperamental